



Adobe Express

Strategic Marketing Plan for
Fall 2025 - Spring 2026



AMERICAN MARKETING
ASSOCIATION



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Digital

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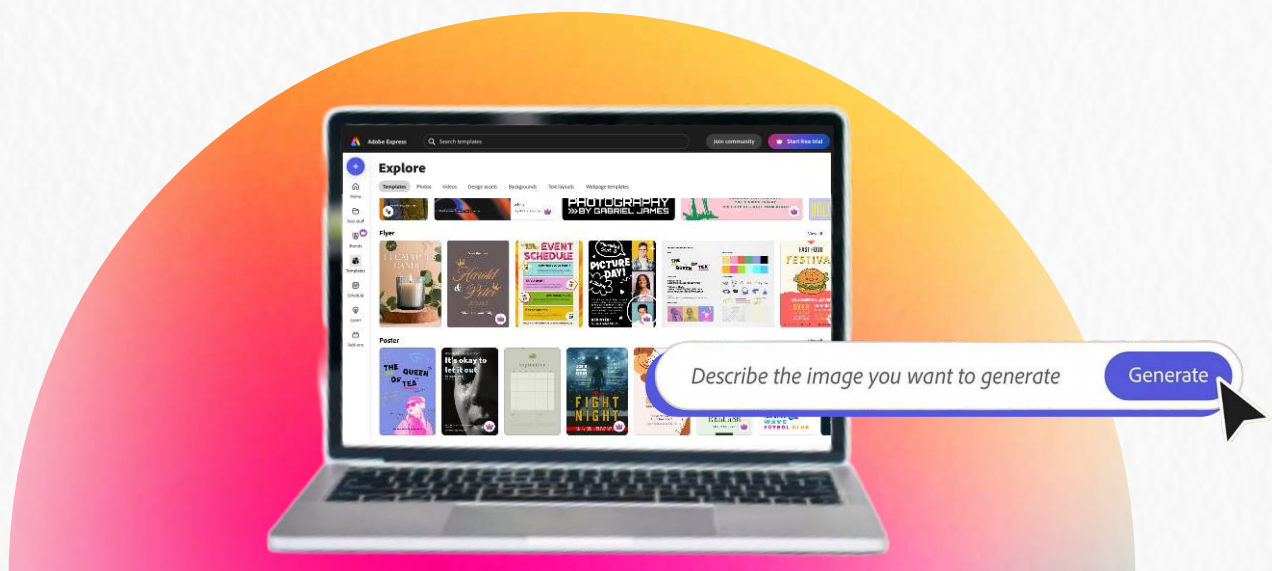
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Executive Summary

With a market capitalization of \$200 billion USD, Adobe is a cornerstone of creativity in the digital age, widely known for its advanced suite of design, content creation tools, and its large global consumer base. Adobe is a company with a robust brand identity, renowned for its development of PhotoShop, Illustrator, InDesign, and Acrobat platforms. However, Adobe offers more than just these staple programs; it provides additional services to empower individuals to take their creativity into their own hands. With digital and multimedia design usage growing among college students, having a platform with all the tools and features essential to producing cohesive, professional, and innovative content to reach both personal and academic goals has become crucial.

In 2021, Adobe Express rebranded into the hub of digital templates and the user-friendly creative hub it is today, offering users a wide selection of easy-to-use design tools. Mainly operating as a content creation tool, Adobe Express provides students with a quick and easy way to work individually and collaboratively on creative projects. The platform offers students a Free Plan through their university emails, giving them fairly non-restrictive access to basic benefits, including thousands of design templates, standard editing tools, and Adobe Stock photos. The sequential subscription option, the Premium Plan, is priced at \$9.99 USD/month and features access to all templates and advanced editing tools. For those wanting to work collaboratively, the Teams Plan is priced at \$7.99 USD/month, including all Premium Plan features as well as a collaboration feature that eases real-time editing among all team members. The Creative Cloud All Apps Plan is priced at \$34.99 USD/month and provides unrestricted access to over 20 Adobe apps.

With the rise of competing content creation tools and platforms, many college students are less familiar with Adobe Express than with other Adobe platforms. To increase brand awareness among students in hopes of converting free trial users into subscribed users, primary and general market research was conducted to gain an enhanced understanding and create an informed strategic marketing plan.



Industry Analysis

Company Background:

Formerly known as "Adobe Spark," Adobe Express is a creation tool developed by Adobe. Adobe was originally founded in 1982 by John Warnock to market a program called PageScript. Today, Adobe Express is an artificial intelligence (AI) hub for graphic design tools, which can be utilized for creative and professional means. Adobe Express is used internationally and possesses a variety of applications to its users, from brand marketing to education. Adobe Express is constantly developing new software to remain competitive in the graphic design market to provide its users with the most advanced technology. As a result of years of development and investment, Adobe is currently worth \$222.05 Billion USD, with revenue driven by subscription plans across its many branches, such as Adobe Acrobat, Adobe Scan, and Adobe Express. Adobe Express has over 43 million users globally, including many K-12 teachers and students. They have also partnered with the California State University (CSU) system, to which Adobe Express has offered exclusive deals to benefit students.

Product History:

Launching in 2016 as "Adobe Spark," the brand mission of Adobe Express is to provide anyone with the tools to be a productive visual designer with an accessible, easy-to-use graphic design platform. From work presentations to social media graphics, Adobe Express provides the tools to create curated visuals for personal and professional use. With the rise in influencer marketing since the COVID-19 pandemic, having a strong online presence is more important than ever. In 2021, Adobe Express rebranded as an all-in-one creation environment equipped with previous design tools, as well as background removal, resizing, and easy access to all templates and fonts in one convenience place. Even in the free version, users have access to thousands of templates of résumés, social media posts, slideshow presentations, reports, multimedia posters, etc.

Industry Trends:

Technological advancements lead to more developed personal preferences within the creative consumption ecosystem. As technology advances, there is a greater consumer need for it, especially with AI. Adobe Express has a wide range of capabilities for students; however, it has yet to tap into this target audience properly.

After conducting a survey distributed to 266 university students in the U.S. ages 17-24, the study found that 64.9% of survey respondents cited they had never heard of Adobe Express, and 86.4% had never used the platform personally. However, over half (66.8%) were interested in its services and willing to consider switching from their current content creation platform. Therefore, it's important for Adobe Express to increase brand awareness among students by introducing its range of functions, promoting offers of free trials with premium features, and providing quick-start tutorials to introduce new users to the platform.

PESTLE

Political

Data privacy, protection, and geopolitical factors are crucial for the global operations of Adobe Express and Adobe overall. Adobe Express manages significant amounts of user data subject to stringent regulations, like the California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA) and the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). As a result, Adobe must maintain compliance to avoid legal and reputational risks, as evident in the company's private data breach in 2013 (Twingate, 2024). Additionally, political stability impacts the ability of Adobe to expand into new markets with geopolitical tensions (Mickinsey, 2023), particularly between the U.S. and China, potentially hindering growth. President Trump's victory in the 2024 U.S. presidential election could also influence Adobe's AI strategy, indicating a likely laissez-faire approach to regulation (Beavins, 2024). Finally, Adobe's Content Authenticity Initiative, aimed at combating misinformation, reflects the company's efforts to foster transparency in AI-generated content. Overall, Adobe's future success depends on balancing technological innovation and compliance with evolving data privacy laws and ethical AI standards to safeguard public concerns about misinformation.

Economical

Recent trends in technology and the digital economy are poised to drive increased demand. With 81 Fortune 500 companies leveraging Adobe software like Photoshop and Adobe Marketing Cloud for digital marketing, Adobe is seeing growth in subscriptions and revenue. The creator economy is expected to double by 2027 (Goldman Sachs, 2023), providing Adobe with an opportunity to tap into the growing demand for accessible, high-quality editing tools, particularly through Adobe Express. In addition, Canva's recent 300% price increase (Weatherbed, 2024) for team subscriptions may lead cost-sensitive small businesses to explore Adobe Express as a more affordable alternative. The global shift towards digital economies and Industry 4.0 also creates opportunities for businesses to innovate and scale, further benefiting companies like Adobe. Gen Z, with projected spending growth to \$12 trillion by 2030 (NielsonIQ, 2024), represents a key demographic for Adobe, and the rise of social commerce and influencer marketing offers additional avenues for Adobe to expand its reach. As the digital economy continues to evolve, Adobe is well-positioned to benefit from these growth trends (BoFA, 2024), especially in the context of a positive economic outlook and increasing brand loyalty among student users.

Social

Adobe differentiates itself as a leader in the market by offering seamless workflows and real-time collaboration through integrations with platforms like Slack. This enables teams to create, review, and refine content more efficiently without the need to switch between multiple tools. This integration enhances productivity, accelerates ideation, and streamlines content creation (Cattell, 2024). In addition, Adobe Express aligns its business strategy with the growing emphasis on Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR), particularly among socially conscious consumer groups, such as Gen Z, who prioritize transparency, sustainability, and inclusivity (Stohl and Stohl, 2007). By embedding CSR initiatives into its core operations, including supporting diversity within creative communities, Adobe protects its brand reputation and fosters deeper loyalty among younger consumers. Furthermore, the integration of Adobe Firefly generative AI into Adobe Express provides both transformative

and user-friendly tools that enable businesses to create high-quality content safely and efficiently, further enhancing the competitive position of Adobe Express in the market.

Technological

Adobe uses AI and Machine Learning to enhance productivity, providing users with tools that go beyond simple automation (Copperman, 2018). Adobe Express uses large, specialized data sets to train algorithms capable of generating data independently, akin to human experience but with a narrower scope. As these processes require advanced graphics processing units, Adobe's recent partnership with NVIDIA (Modi, 2024), a major industrial force, highlights its reliance on cutting-edge technology. The National Library of Medicine (Pascucci, 2023) emphasizes how AI and data analytics reshape digital marketing, streamlining operations and enabling customer-specific advertisements. The Harvard Business Review (Davenport, 2021) expands on this, noting how AI chatbots and automated tools on platforms like Adobe Express personalize user experiences and bring consumer visions to life, further demonstrating the transformative role of AI and machine-based learning in Adobe's technological strategies and platform development.

Legal

Legal challenges are an important issue for Adobe Express as it adapts to the changing rules around AI and digital platforms. Foley & Lardner LLP highlights potential problems, like overlapping patents, as companies create similar innovations, with Adobe Express possibly facing risks if it looks too similar to competitors (Allen and Lehot, 2024). Data privacy and security are concerns, as platforms like Adobe handle sensitive user information, which could lead to misuse (Violino, 2022). Global laws such as GDPR (EU), CCPA/CPRA (California), and PIPL (China) make compliance more complex, and the EU AI Act will directly impact Adobe's AI, like Firefly. Data localization laws in countries like Russia and Brazil add to these challenges, increasing costs and operational difficulties. The American Civil Liberties Union (ACLU) has pushed for stronger protections for online data and health records to address these risks (ACLU, 2024). Recent antitrust lawsuits, like Adobe's inability to purchase Figma (Ford 2024), convey the importance of following competition laws. Accordance with copyright, data use, and tax regulations will help Adobe avoid legal trouble and remain competitive.

Environmental

Western governments are transitioning toward clean energy across a variety of markets, which matches Adobe's goal of using only renewable energy by 2035 (Adobe, 2024). Adobe products, including Adobe Express, help reduce environmental impact by supporting paperless work. Data centers, essential for digital operations, also consume significant energy for cooling and powering equipment. Initiatives, including the European Code of Conduct on Data Centers, recommend using energy-efficient equipment and better power management to reduce this impact (Feltin, 2021). With these international codes in mind, Adobe can further its environmental goals and minimize its footprint.

Situational Analysis

SWOT

STRENGTHS

User-Friendly Software:

Adobe tools, such as Photoshop, Illustrator, and Acrobat, are industry-standard, trusted tools, unify the brand across platforms. This reliability drives users to continue working with the brand, reducing the likelihood they will turn toward competitors. Adobe Express ensures that their platform tools remain useful and well-liked by regularly introducing updates.

AI Integration:

Utilizing AI not only proves Adobe Express' ability to adapt to new technologies but also demonstrates its commitment to enhancing the user experience. Adobe's AI software, Firefly, offers users automation, design recommendations, and data insights, fostering creativity and efficiency.

Brand Ethics:

Adobe was named one of America's Most Just Companies for the seventh consecutive year (Adobe, 2024). This list is determined by staff investment, community support, and environmental impact. Adobe was named under the CDP 2022 A-List and the CDP 2022 Supplier Engagement List for sustainable efforts within the supply chain.

WEAKNESSES

Expense:

Although Adobe offers free versions of its software, access is limited. Comparing the differences in the free software offered by Adobe and Canva, smaller businesses and individual users would likely utilize Canva since it offers more options. Though the pricing is similar between these two companies overall, some students may be intimidated by the professionalism associated with the Adobe brand, which may lead them to assume Adobe Express is more expensive or confusing compared to Canva.

Social Media Presence:

As of 2024, Adobe has 52.9k followers and 1.8 million likes on TikTok, a reel-focused social media app, with content spread across 922 videos. Although this is a large number of followers, especially for a software company, Canva outpaces Adobe with 569k followers and 2.3 million likes dispersed across 601 videos.

Lack of Free Media Options:

Looking at the media offered by Canva, it provides more resources than Adobe, including a larger selection of templates, transition effects, and language options. The extra resources put forward by Canva may draw more users toward their site instead of Adobe Express.

OPPORTUNITIES

Increase Partner Collaborations:

Expansion of partnerships and collaborations with companies involved in technology, hardware manufacturers, and service providers will drive Adobe's revenue streams. These partnerships will also help Adobe Express stay relevant with new trends (The Strategy Story, 2024).

Further Developing AI Tools

As AI continues to grow, investing in developing an AI tool to enhance user experience will reinforce Adobe Express's reputation as an 'easier-to-use' platform, becoming more appealing to customers. New customers who are unfamiliar with Adobe Express software will be attracted to a simple tool that can ease users' experiences. This AI tool can also be designed to cater to users' personal needs and address their specific values, increasing customer loyalty. Furthermore, the lack of a spell-checking algorithm in Adobe Express may leave students vulnerable to producing work with spelling or grammar errors.

Expansion Into Emerging Countries

Adobe Express can expand its global presence by becoming involved in the development of digital design and marketing tools in emerging countries and economies. By offering solutions that appeal to local problems, partnering with local businesses, and investing in the development of marketing efforts in these emerging markets, Adobe Express can capitalize on the rise in demand for digital solutions. For example, India is an emerging economy where its residents are experiencing an increase in their buying power. If Adobe's products are more intertwined with this market, their software will be in high demand and have a presence in this rising economy.

THREATS***Everchanging Technological Advancements***

Technology is a fast-changing industry that is always evolving, so it is important to not only stay up to date with advancements but to be ahead in the race of trends and developments. Other companies and their services may hold the lead over Adobe and its offerings, including Adobe Express. They will continue to have constant pressure to produce a product, service, or tool that will captivate the lead in advancements.

Cybersecurity Breaches

Cybersecurity threats are no stranger to companies like Adobe Express, becoming a concern to customers and sometimes influencing their trust and decisions to use software. These breaches are detrimental to their reputation, finances, and operations, causing legal liabilities (Krebs, 2013). Adobe has already had a cybersecurity breach that put a dent in its reputation in 2013, where the information of at least 38 million Adobe users was stolen by hackers. The information includes usernames, passwords, and credit card information. They also obtained source code of Adobe products, including Photoshop.

Neck to Neck Competition

There is a number of software providers that are in direct competition with Adobe Express by providing similar services and products. Major software companies like Microsoft, Apple, and Google provide lines of services that indirectly compete with Adobe by providing various software products. Canva is a graphic design tool that targets user-friendly customers, becoming Adobe Express' biggest competitor to the college student audience. Adobe Express has added pressure to stay consistently innovative and unique to be the leader in its market.

Market Analysis

COMPETITOR ANALYSIS

Canva

In a primary research survey that was conducted amongst 266 university students, 80% of respondents actively used the free version of Canva as a content creation platform. However, 40% of respondents thought that the premium version of their current content creation platform was too expensive, and 30% said that the free version was too limited. This data demonstrates how college students are looking for a quality product at an affordable price, and it additionally identifies Canva as the main competitor of Adobe Express within the college student demographic.

As an online design platform with a simple and easy-to-use interface, Canva allows users to create professional-looking visual content such as flyers, résumés, presentations, posters, and more (Kumar, 2024). Canva offers a vast library of free-to-use templates and stock images and promotes team collaboration through its online interface. They have an immense user base, with 170 million active monthly users, making up 12.47% of the market share in the graphics market (Kumar, 2024). They primarily target non-graphic designers, such as local businesses, students, and teachers, with the last two consumer categories encompassing 60 million users. Canva now features AI-powered tools, such as Image and Art Generators, Magic Design, etc.

Canva advertises annual subscription rates, compared to Adobe Express' monthly rates. The tiers include Canva Free, Canva Pro (\$120 USD/person), Canva Teams (\$100 USD/year), and Canva Enterprise (varies). This breaks down to \$10 USD per month with the Pro version, while the Teams version costs \$8.33 USD per user when split among at least three account users. Comparatively, Adobe Express has nearly equal rates for their first tier of paid subscriptions and lower rates for teams. Although most users take advantage of Canva's free package, 16 million subscribers are paying for one of the subscriptions as of Q1 2024, totaling a revenue of \$2 billion in the previous year. While Canva is a strong entry-level graphic design platform known to the college student demographic, it lacks certain professional-grade and premium features that Adobe Express provides its users, such as video editing and higher-quality graphics, giving Adobe Express a higher professional-quality output. Adobe Express can act as a gateway into other Adobe platforms via the Creative Cloud All Apps Plan, which competitors like Canva cannot match. Informing consumers of this comparative difference is one opportunity to poach Canva users.

Pixlr

Pixlr is a photo editing and graphic design tool that is used on a computer or mobile phone. It is widely used for photo touch-ups, quick edits, and creating social media graphics. Similarly to Canva, it possesses AI tools and has a minimal learning curve with quick edit features, making it more commonly used by non-graphic designers. Despite this, Pixlr still does not have the versatility of applications like Canva or the Adobe Express Creative Suite. Pixlr has over 16 million active users worldwide (Enlyft, 2024), making up around 0.01% of the market share. The user interface is incredibly easy to use, but unless users upgrade to the \$5 USD monthly premium package, they're bombarded with an abundance of advertisements.

SketchUp

SketchUp holds the fifth largest share of the graphic design market at 3.78%, trailing behind applications such as Adobe Photoshop, InDesign, Illustrator, and Canva (Vailshery, 2024). Unlike Adobe Express, SketchUp is a 3D modeling software designed primarily for professionals in fields like architectural design, interior design, engineering, and product design. Its steeper learning curve makes it less accessible to non-designers, such as most college students and small business owners. SketchUp is not commonly used for marketing, advertising, or content creation, making it less relevant in the social media and branding space that Adobe Express should target.

CONSUMER INSIGHTS

Consumer Demographics

The target market for Adobe Express encompasses university students ages 17-24. This consumer demographic is selectively Gen Z. As of 2024, there are 4,360 higher education institutions in the US, and about 72% of students are enrolled in a public school (Hanson, 2024). A persistent gender gap has grown since the 1970s amongst those enrolled to achieve a Bachelor's Degree, with 54% of women obtaining a four-year degree versus 43% of men (Reeves and Secker, 2024).

Behavioral Characteristics

Knowing that the target audience is college students between 17-24 years old, their purchase behavior is budget-conscious. Shoppers in this age group often wait for sales or use discount codes to prioritize value. They favor loyalty programs for long-term savings and strategic purchases, with 71% preferring to wait for discounts rather than paying full price (Boyle, 2024). Seasonal trends like back-to-school shopping and Cyber Week create significant opportunities, with spending spikes on electronics and supplies totaling billions annually. Adobe Express Experience Cloud data reveals that targeted discounts during major sales events like Black Friday and Prime Day effectively drive consumer spending (Adobe Express, 2024).

Psychographic Characteristics

Advancements in AI and digital design tools are reshaping customer expectations. Adobe Express's AI-driven features align well with Gen Z's demand for accessible, innovative, and collaborative tools, particularly on college campuses where creativity and usability are essential. Like never before, Gen Z is encouraged to see themselves as unique, personal brands. This extends beyond their purchasing behavior, as they are not merely purchasing products they feel are aligned with their values. People below the age of 30 have come of age in a time in which it is common to project an online persona into the digital world, interacting with their peers and with companies in this way. Students curate social media profiles to project the kind of person they want to be viewed as, and they are at a transitional period in their lives in which people are heavily negotiating their identities.

Communication Channels

Social media significantly influences Gen Z's purchasing decisions, with platforms like TikTok and Instagram driving trends through influencers, user-generated content, and brand collaborations. Peer recommendations and social validation also play a key role, with 52.5% of college students trying new products based on a friend's suggestion (Fareq et al., 2024). As a result of this, the best way to communicate with Gen Z is through social media, as they are highly socially conscious, diverse, and internet-savvy. As the first generation raised with the modern internet, they are deeply connected online, making social platforms an effective channel for engagement (Drenik, 2023). On social media, Gen Z values user-generated content and personalization, with AI tools enhancing tailored advertisements and creative expression. Moreover, data privacy remains a concern for 79% of consumers, highlighting the importance of incorporating robust security measures, such as E2EE, to build trust and encourage premium service adoption (Kadet, 2022).

Market Research

PRIMARY RESEARCH

Objective

To collect primary data regarding the purchasing habits and trends of the target market, a survey of 266 college students was conducted across several universities to gather insights. The primary objective of this survey was to evaluate college students' familiarity with Adobe Express, understand their preferences, and identify what they value most in a content creation service. The insights gained from this study aim to inform strategies for enhancing Adobe Express's appeal, usability, and subscription rates among college-aged users.

Methodology

This anonymous survey was sent to students across a college campus through a Google Form. It consisted of 15 questions, both multiple-choice and free-response, to gather information about consumer demographics and purchasing behaviors. Quantitative data from closed-ended questions were subjected to statistical analysis, while open-ended questions were qualitatively analyzed to uncover common themes. Since this was a voluntary survey targeted toward college students, this sample is not representative and cannot be generalized to the broader public.

Results

Trend 1: Familiarity with Adobe Programs

In the primary research survey among 266 college students, 10.2% of the students indicated frequent and regular usage of Adobe programs. 48.3% reported themselves as somewhat familiar with Adobe programs, which implies their limited awareness and occasional use of Adobe software.

Trend 2: Semi-Familiarity with Adobe Express

64.9% of respondents cited they never heard of Adobe Express, and 86.4% of respondents had never used the platform personally. However, over half of respondents (66.8%) were interested in its services and were willing to consider switching from their current content creation platform. Therefore, it's important for Adobe Express to increase brand awareness among students by introducing its range of functions, promoting offers of free trials with premium features, and providing quick-start tutorials to inoculate new users with the platform quickly.

Trend 3: Factors Impacting Content Creation Platform Choice

According to the data, 59.2% of respondents indicated that ease of use was important to them, 50.0% indicated that affordability was important, and 40% indicated that the range of features was important. 49.8% of respondents report a willingness to pay less than \$10 a month for a graphic design platform. Following this, 33.5% of respondents report a interest in free platforms only. In the free response portion of the survey, students who have used Adobe Express indicated they would prefer improved ease of the surface-level design features, specifically requesting the ability to easily re-select colors on the page and to have customizable margins that automatically adapt, to further enhance spatial awareness and ease of use.

Strategy, Positioning & Objectives

Moving forward, Adobe Express should prioritize maintaining a more accessible social media presence and offering benefits directly to the target audience of Gen Z college students, largely through a series of social media campaigns that relate to the diverse "types" of students who use Adobe Express for varying purposes. Participatory "challenges" and robust influencer partnerships will lead to high engagement, which Adobe Express has the resources to achieve. Nonetheless, to execute the goal of converting Gen Z students into subscribed users paying for one of the Adobe Express payment plans, Adobe Express must optimize a multi-platform approach to social marketing. Social media campaigns and immersive on-campus experiences are designed to target student organizations to boost brand visibility and recognition across all channels. Embracing social marketing overall has a low opportunity cost, as it can target the algorithms of the target audience and overall promote the digital assets offered by the Adobe Express interface.

Value Proposition:

A. Professional Association

According to a recent study conducted by Handshake, 54% of college seniors, as of August 2024, are pessimistic when thinking about entering the job market (Handshake, 2024). The competitive reality many face for an entry-level position has grown increasingly fierce due to credential inflation, or the devaluation of degree achievement in the job market. Furthermore, students fear being replaced by AI, and many grapple with high student loans post-graduation. In the primary research survey, many free-response answers indicated that Adobe Express possesses a more professional connotation than Canva or other competitors. Catering toward high-achieving, pre-professionally-minded students, Adobe Express provides students with accessible tools to curate professional work products to use in university courses or career settings. Potentially aligning itself with other brands that display a similar reverence of professionalism and post-graduation success, like LinkedIn, Adobe Express can signal its advantages over other competitor platforms to students deciding between design interfaces.

B. User-Friendliness

Students are attracted to easy-to-use graphic design sites, given their busy workloads balancing several courses per academic year. Having a responsive, quickly learned interface is key to maintaining users, who require an interface that loads quickly and can be easily edited to meet the consumer's vision; Adobe Express already possesses this.

C. A.I. Integration

Students have grown increasingly dependent on AI to assist them in completing assignments. Many colleges have adopted policies around generative AI to encourage "responsible" use of the platform rather than totally admonishing it (Henry, 2023). As of 2023, nearly a third of college students were using ChatGPT. As the AI market grows, students also have begun using AI to edit their assignments, explain confusing essay prompts, or write emails. Therefore, having accessible and easy-to-use AI enables Adobe Express to make work more efficient and convenient for students, while still enabling them to take a creative approach to graphic design.

Marketing Campaigns

CAMPAIGN IDEA 1:

"Rep Your Colors" Merchandise Design Competition

Objective

The "Rep Your Colors" campaign seeks to drive awareness and the adoption of Adobe Express among college students by engaging them in a nationwide merchandise design competition. This campaign encourages students to leverage the already existing merchandise templates to create custom college-inspired merchandise, such as phone cases, stickers, lounge sets, and hats. By harnessing the power of campus pride, Adobe Express can convey its value by helping to create the products students want, thus solidifying its position as the top design tool.

Positioning

Adobe Express is positioned as an accessible platform that enables all students of all academic levels and backgrounds to produce professional-quality designs for their clubs, organizations, and personal expression. This campaign differentiates Adobe Express from competitors (Canva, Custom Ink) by engaging students nationwide through their platform of choice: social media. Through this competition, Adobe Express will be perceived not only as the "relevant" design tool but an integral part of the college lifestyle. This approach conveys the customizability of the platform, which prides itself on supporting student needs.

Target Audience

The primary audience for this campaign is college students involved in student organizations, Greek life, club sports, and other campus-based groups that often produce merchandise each semester. This demographic frequently seeks customizable merchandise for events and team building, and the Adobe Express platform meets these needs while allowing students to showcase their school pride and creativity.

Campaign Execution

Graphic Design Competition

This national design competition will be advertised through Instagram and TikTok to invite students to create original, campus-themed graphics to be featured on various merchandise. Participants will use Adobe Express design tools to create and submit their designs, and the top 3-5 campus winners will be gifted their designs. All participants can ultimately have their designs made through an easy export to a third-party production site.

Merchandise and Prizes

Winning designs will be printed on various merchandise options and distributed, which will be promoted across Adobe Express social media accounts. Winners will also receive a one-year subscription to Adobe Express Premium, providing access to advanced design features. Adobe Express can sell the winning designs to a broader market through an Adobe-hosted online store, with proceeds supporting scholarship funds.

Social Media Amplification

Students will be encouraged to share their design entries on social media using the hashtag #RepYourColors. The Adobe Express social media channels will feature selected designs, showcasing student creativity and amplifying the reach of the campaign. This social media presence will also help build a community of student designers and campus advocates.

Campus Ambassador Program:

Adobe Express campus ambassadors could play a critical role in promoting the competition. Ambassadors will leverage their diverse audiences, introducing students to Adobe Express and its design capabilities. These ambassadors will emphasize Adobe Express Pro benefits, characterizing Adobe Express as a trusted and relevant brand on college campuses.

Competitive Context:

The college merchandise market is growing rapidly, with popular brands like Lululemon and Urban Outfitters creating their own university product series. Many student organizations use platforms like Canva and Custom Ink to create their own merchandise, particularly for club-specific apparel and stickers. Adobe Express distinguishes itself with professional-grade design features, making it a compelling choice for students who prioritize both creativity and access to extensive features. By embedding Adobe Express into the collegiate experience, this campaign reinforces the brand's relevance and competitive edge amongst students.

Metrics for Success:

Key performance indicators (KPIs) for this campaign include engagement metrics (number of contest entries, social media engagement under #RepYourColors). Adobe Express should measure platform adoption, such as increases in Adobe Express account creation and free-to-premium subscription conversions during the campaign period. Finally, the merchandise sales and fundraising can be tracked for the winning design in an online storefront.



*Instagram Promotional Mock-Ups,
Images 1-3*

CAMPAIGN IDEA 2:**#ExpressYourself & Social Influencer Marketing****Objective:**

The #ExpressYourself campaign aims to partner with several content creators to position Adobe Express as the leading tool for college students to curate their personal brand and unique social media presence. By collaborating with influencers who are also college students, this campaign will demonstrate how manageable it is to balance school life with content creation with the help of Adobe Express Pro. In their content, creators will show how they utilize Adobe Express in the behind-the-scenes of making their school assignments and online posts, from podcasts to TikTok videos to Instagram carousels. By emphasizing the platform's ease and variety of tools, the campaign will showcase how students can start their own free trial to create eye-catching posts, videos, and portfolios to represent themselves. Creators will use the tag #ExpressMyself across social media to convey the brand partnership. The goal is to demonstrate how the Adobe Express free trial is both a creative outlet and a gateway into the professional world of content creation.

Positioning:

Adobe Express positions itself as an easy-to-use tool for everyone, regardless of their previous experience with content creation. With features such as brand kits and an all-in-one editor, Adobe Express is the perfect platform for college students hoping to make a name for themselves or score well on a school presentation. Its simple and beginner-friendly features make content creation seamlessly fit into the busy schedule of a student. Free trials and student pricing make it more affordable for students on a budget.

Target Audience:

The #ExpressYourself campaign targets college students aspiring to establish a social media presence or who are meticulous when designing their school presentations and projects. By collaborating with students involved in design, film, media, and business, the campaign establishes credibility by being relatable to the audience. In an effort to connect with multiple demographics, the campaign will feature creators of different genders, majors, schools, and audiences.

Execution:

An oversight team can manage the contracting of several social creators across different social media platforms. It is recommended to contract partnerships on a semester basis to assess the success of a specific creator in galvanizing their audience to use Adobe Express. It would be ideal to work with vetted mid-tier influencers (50K-100,00K followers), given they are dependable in their posting schedules and are not too costly, ranging anywhere from \$500 to \$5,000 USD per post (Hitchcock, 2024). Recruiting a diverse roster of content creators that can appeal to both male and female audiences, as well as across a variety of student experiences, is also ideal. An example of diversifying the creators worked with includes contracting with one creator who is very active in Greek life while also working with a student-athlete in a way that is authentic to the Adobe Express brand.

Recommended Creators:

A. Nicole Laeno (@NicoelLaeno)

Nicole is a first-year communication student at San Diego State University. She has 1.9 million Instagram followers, 5.7 million TikTok followers, and 3.64 million YouTube subscribers. Along with being a student and influencer, Nicole is on the SDSU Dance Team. It would be ideal to commission Nicole to make a "Day in My Life" vlog-style video in which she uses Adobe Express for both her schoolwork and content creation. This content would show the program's versatility and ease of use for students.

B. Avery Kroll (@AveryKroll)

Kroll is a second-year business student at the University of Arizona. She has 688,600 TikTok followers and 102,000 Instagram followers. Many of her TikTok videos follow the "get ready with me" or "day in my life" format. She could use Adobe Express to create a customized digital planner to organize her busy days. Avery could also use Adobe Express to design study guides, flashcards, or slides for her business classes and tests.

C. Student-Athlete

As of 2021, student-athletes are now allowed to profit from their name, image, and likeness, meaning that Adobe Express can help college athletes create a cohesive brand identity. Student-athletes can utilize the software to create templates for game day preparation, highlights, and statistics. Athletes on the same team can use collaboration features to share a schedule, share team statistics, and create an overall team brand. By partnering with student-athletes, Adobe can convey its value as a tool to students who are constantly on the go and are heavily involved in extracurriculars, like the 520,000 NCAA athletes in the United States.

D. Jemma Violet (@JemmaViolent)

Violet is a micro-influencer and student at the University of British Columbia and has 495,900 followers on TikTok. Her brand encapsulates a studious persona, as she makes videos about her lengthy study sessions and advertises tips for other students. One of her study methods is a study crawl, where she goes to different libraries and cafés throughout the day to study. Jemma could make a video utilizing Adobe Express to create a map of her favorite study crawl spots. In one of her videos, Violet utilizes the Cornell note-taking method to help her study for a big test the next day. She could create a personalized Cornell template using Adobe Express to advertise to her massive following.



TikTok Mock-Up, Image 4

CAMPAIGN IDEA 3:**"Success with Express" Pre-Professional Workshops****Objective**

The "Success with Express" initiative is focused on helping students and educators improve their digital literacy and creative skills, preparing them for the post-graduation professional world. Adobe Express must promote the simplicity of creating professional-quality content for both academic and professional purposes. Through professional development workshops, campus visits, and LinkedIn integration, Adobe Express can promote messaging around making creativity practical and essential to elevate one's digital media skills for entry-level and advanced professional positions. The goal is to position Adobe Express as a must-have tool for students and educators while also boosting its reputation as a key part of digital learning and career readiness.

Positioning

The "Success with Express" program focuses on showing students and educators that Adobe Express is more than just a design tool: it's a way to build skills, enhance projects, and stand out professionally. By exploring Adobe Express, students can showcase their creativity and gain an edge in the job market. Additionally, the program highlights how Adobe Express has a role in supporting diverse career paths, such as sales, graphic design, real estate, and more. This program stands out because it combines creative learning with career preparation, something Canva and other competitors have yet to address fully.

Target Audience

The demographics of students this campaign will target should be those studying STEM, business, economics, marketing, and pre-law, as these students are typically very motivated to be competitive applicants for graduate school or future employment. For students, the workshops will help create opportunities to learn digital design and prepare students for future careers.

Program Execution

Adobe Express will host workshops where students and educators can learn how to use Adobe Express for real-world projects. These include data visualization, video creation, and building engaging presentations. The workshops offer hands-on training, making the learning process easy and interactive, and could potentially connect students to internship opportunities at Adobe Express or other Adobe companies. A collaboration with LinkedIn could be explored, as participants who complete the workshops could potentially earn a new "Adobe Express Certified" badge to display on their LinkedIn profiles.

Campus Visits

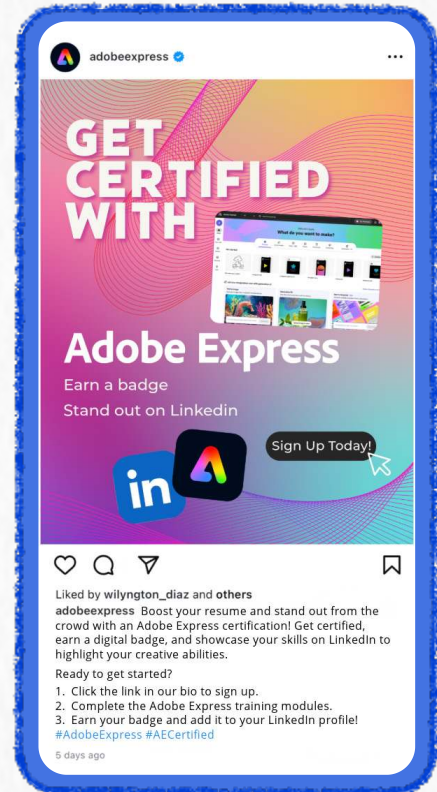
Adobe Express experts could visit over 100+ universities to provide on-site support and guidance. These visits will include live demos, Q&A sessions, and collaboration with educators to integrate Adobe Express into their curricula. A major focus will be on helping students become "Adobe Express Certified" and showcasing how Adobe Express can be used to explore various career paths, such as graphic design, real estate, and marketing.

LinkedIn Integration

Students and educators who complete the workshops or online courses can add these certifications to their LinkedIn profiles. This integration demonstrates to potential employers that participants are proficient in professional-grade creative tools, giving them an advantage over competitors.

Competitive Context

Many students and educators currently use tools like Canva or Microsoft design software to meet their creative needs. These platforms are known for their simplicity, but Canva specifically lacks the professional association possessed by Adobe Express. What further sets Adobe Express apart is its ability to grow with users as their skills develop. Adobe Express, unlike Microsoft or any other notorious professional platform, can offer unique opportunities to students specifically that competitors do not provide, thus encouraging long-term subscriptions for students even after they graduate. By targeting high-performing students and emphasizing Adobe's prestige, the program positions Adobe Express as the go-to platform for serious creatives and professionals.

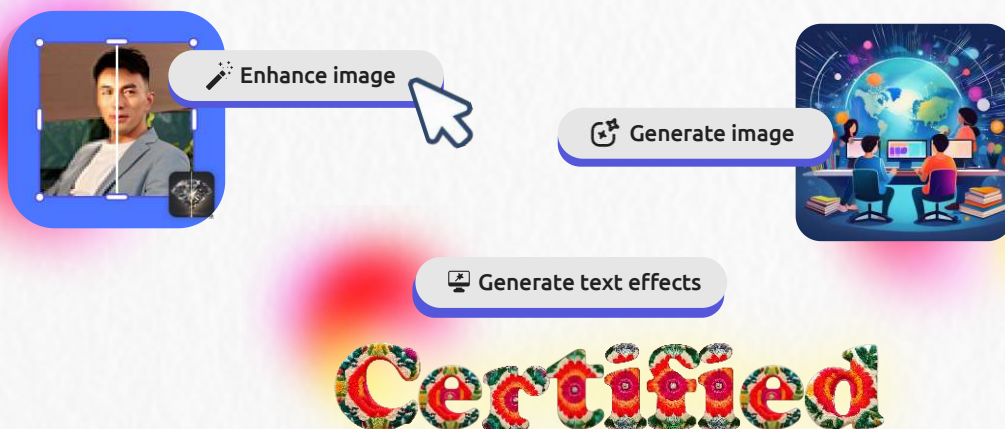


Social Mock-Up, Image 5

Metrics for Success

Success can be measured by tracking the number of participants in workshops and campus visits, as well as monitoring social media engagement from students sharing their projects and certifications. Additionally, increases in Adobe Express account sign-ups and premium upgrades should be tracked, especially among students and educators. Finally, Adobe Express can measure how many participants add Adobe Express certifications to their LinkedIn profiles.

Master Every Tool with Adobe Express



CAMPAIGN IDEA 4:**Film Photo "E-Booth" Pop-Ups****Objective**

The objective of this proposed campaign is to increase brand awareness and engagement with Adobe Express among college students by leveraging interactive, fun, and shareable photo booths across college campuses in the U.S. In the high-tech booths, students can use Adobe Express templates for their photos. The E-booths also should feature a QR code that directs students to their photos in the Adobe Express app, where they can edit the templates and share them on social media. This marketing tactic promotes brand awareness and face-to-face consumer engagement, a strategy many brands have adopted to target Gen-Z. For example, Samsung launched a 360-photo booth pop-up series around the world, allowing people to take photos using their 360-degree photo technology. Similarly, Rhode, a skincare brand founded by Hailey Bieber, brought the 'Rhode Booth' to Toronto, Canada; London; Miami; and Los Angeles, where consumers could take photos, sample free cosmetic products, and purchase coffee drinks from an on-site barista stand.

Positioning

By offering a hands-on experience that is both unique and immersive, these pop-ups demonstrate the platform's user-friendly design tools and creative capabilities, encouraging students to incorporate it into their personal and academic projects. By focusing on major metropolitan areas and large college towns, students can have their questions about the platform answered by on-site staff. Finally, they will learn about Adobe Express in an entertaining and engaging way that is difficult for other brands to emulate directly. This strategy will lead students to integrate the platform into their everyday creative endeavors, such as personal projects, class assignments, and social media content. This marketing approach aligns with Adobe Express brand values of creativity, innovation, and serving students both in and out of the classroom.

Target Audience

The E-booths aim to engage students who are unfamiliar with Adobe programs and can be personally reached and interacted with on the way to their classes. The booths provide a quick, efficient in-person experience while also offering an opportunity for friends to come together to take a photo, creating valuable assets to share on social media and word-of-mouth testimonials. These kinds of booths often generate excitement online as people eagerly anticipate where the booth will pop up next, creating a substantial opportunity to promote the Adobe Express brand and services to a younger audience.

Program Execution

The booths can be easily recreated across college campuses by an operational team. While it may be challenging to set up booths nationwide, due to the cost of travel and transporting materials, Adobe can target select campuses in specific regions or focus on larger college campuses to convert students into Adobe Express users. Students should be encouraged to post on social media, enhancing the "viral" potential of this approach, which relies not solely on professional content creators but on everyday people.

Tactics

Instagram

As of April 2024, Instagram was the third most popular social network worldwide in terms of number of monthly active users. It is the leading social media platform among Gen Z, with 59% of Gen Z users engaging with it multiple times daily (Dixon, 2024). Using Instagram reels to promote the use of Adobe Express will likely increase engagement among younger demographics, including Gen Z. Reels are short, creative, and trend-based content. Many well-known college influencers are highly active on Instagram. By collaborating with college-aged influencers, advertisements are likely to reach the target audience of college students effectively. An example of a collaboration with an influencer could be a "Day-In-My-Life" style reel in which the influencer takes viewers through a day in their life. In the video, the influencer can be seen using Adobe Express to work on their résumé or even using Adobe Express to create a trendy Instagram post.

TikTok

While many social media platforms impact Gen Z, TikTok dominates a majority of the screen time for this "chronically online" demographic. Approximately 40% of Gen Z has utilized TikTok as their main search engine over the past four years (Hart, 2022), and many use TikTok in place of Google or other search engines. TikTok is very sensitive to Internet trends, which any company can tap into by using popular sounds and mimicking popular online jargon or humor. Investing in "boosting" Adobe Express content on the app will guarantee that the content is worked into the target demographic's algorithm. Adobe Express should expand its video editing templates or partner to create its own TikTok filter that can be used in the app, thus driving traffic to its own site.

LinkedIn

As of 2024, LinkedIn has more than 1 billion members in 200 countries and regions worldwide (Witt, 2024). Tools such as Creator Mode and Audience Network can aid the Adobe brand to broaden its reach and connect with new audiences. College students comprise 46 million LinkedIn users (Sitarz, 2023), and use the app to look for jobs or internships, network with professionals, and to post updates about their own academic and professional involvement. Users can display earned certifications on their profiles, and many Adobe badges already exist on the app; creating an Adobe Express badge would promote the professional association with Adobe, elevating it over competitors.

YouTube

YouTube has 2.5 billion active users worldwide, and studies show that 91% of viewers use YouTube to discover new brands or products; furthermore, 70% of users have purchased a product after seeing it on YouTube (Dunn, 2024). As video content has a high retention rate, viewers have been known to recall up to 95% of a video message compared to just 10% of text content, making YouTube a strong medium for delivering impactful marketing messages (Dunn, 2024). Adobe Express may consider launching a 60-second video series with user-generated content (UGC) to highlight various design applications. By curating testimonial-style videos showcasing real user success stories, such as hosting a Q&A about the platform or updating existing lesson planning, users can promote a wide variety of content without the substantial time constraints of TikTok or Instagram reels.

Facebook Ads

In 2023, only 33% of U.S. teens said they used Facebook, according to the Pew Research Center. However, the platform still offers potential for engaging college students, especially with its revamped features like Groups, Marketplace, and Reels (Chandonnet, 2024). Adobe Express can target specific Facebook groups and events, as many students belong to exclusive Facebook groups related to school housing, community updates, and class advice.

Focus on Local Events and Campus Engagement

Facebook's 'Local tab' features like geo-targeted events, which Adobe Express can utilize to run campus-specific campaigns. By promoting local design contests, Adobe Express workshops, or student project showcases, the platform can directly connect with college communities. One campaign idea is to have students submit their creative projects—like posters or flyers made using Adobe Express—and vote for their favorites in a public Facebook group. The top designs win Adobe Express merchandise or premium access.

Snapchat Ads

As of 2024, Snapchat reaches 90% of 13 to 24-year-olds in the U.S. and approximately 75% of 13 to 34-year-olds in over 25 countries (Snapchat, 2024). Snapchat offers many marketing opportunities for businesses, including single-image or video ads, collection and story ads, non-skippable commercials, and immersive tools, like AR Lenses and filters. All of these align perfectly with Adobe Express's focus on visual creativity, which in turn can promote brand awareness and boost engagement with college demographics.

Referral Programs

Referral programs are a key strategy that can significantly enhance social media marketing efforts. These programs promote more sales and also foster loyal customers (Adobe, 2024). These programs are cost-effective, as they primarily rely on existing members to promote the product, thus eliminating the need for substantial financial investment (Adobe, 2018). One potential approach for Adobe Express is to encourage students to showcase their work by tagging Adobe Express in their posts, while also tagging a friend who might be interested in exploring the product.



Instagram Promotional Mock-Up, Image 6

Metrics

The proposed campaigns have a combined budget of \$7.5 million out of the total \$10 million set aside for this initiative. This strategic decision leaves an additional \$2.5 million in reserve to allow for flexible spending if needed and to further develop the software of Adobe Express to maximize AI and collaborative tools. This reserve can amplify successful aspects of the campaign, such as extending influencer partnerships or boosting high-performing social media ads.

Campaign Idea 1: "Rep Your Colors" Merchandise Design Competition

The key performance indicators (KPIs) for this campaign are designed to measure its overall effectiveness across engagement, platform adoption, and sales impact. Engagement metrics will include the total number of contest entries, social media interactions under the #RepYourColors hashtag (likes, shares, and comments), and attendance figures for campus ambassador-led events. Platform adoption will be assessed by tracking the increase in Adobe Express account sign-ups and the conversion rate from free to premium subscriptions among students during the campaign period. Additionally, merchandise sales and fundraising will be monitored through the revenue generated from winning designs sold via an online store, as well as contributions to scholarship programs or sustainability initiatives. These KPIs will provide a comprehensive view of the campaign's success, encompassing reach, engagement, user acquisition, and social impact.

Campaign Idea 2: #ExpressYourself Social Influencer Marketing

The KPIs for the #ExpressYourself Social Influence Marketing campaign focus on engagement, platform adoption, and career integration. Engagement metrics will include tracking the number of participants in workshops and campus visits and monitoring social media interactions from students sharing their projects and certifications. Platform adoption will be measured by increases in Adobe Express account sign-ups, particularly among students and educators, as well as the rate at which users upgrade to the Premium version after participating in the program. Career integration metrics will involve analyzing how many participants add Adobe Express certifications to their LinkedIn profiles and gathering feedback from educators on the impact of Adobe Express on classroom creativity and student engagement. These KPIs will collectively provide valuable insights into the campaign's success, from user participation and platform growth to its influence on education and professional development.

Campaign Ideas 3&4: Campus Visits

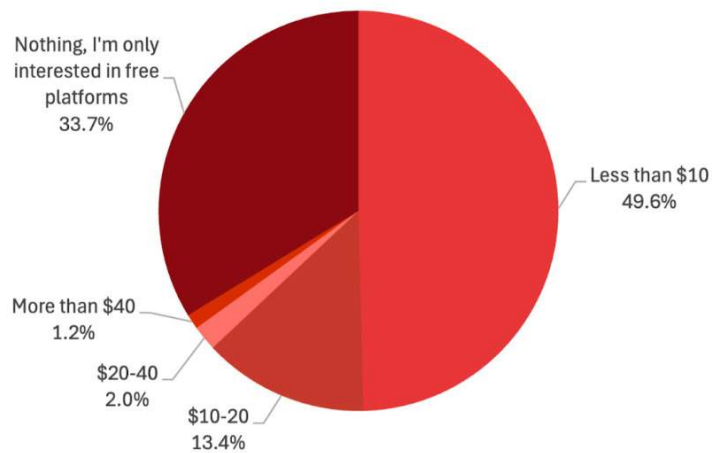
The KPIs will focus on measuring engagement, adoption, and conversion to evaluate effectiveness. Promotion will utilize social media channels, mainly TikTok and Instagram, to share testimonials and workshop success stories, complemented by email outreach to student organizations and academic departments. Engagement metrics will include likes, shares, comments, and video views to track user interest and interaction, providing insight into campaign reach. Conversion tracking will be used to measure the number of students who sign up for Adobe Express through these social media channels, assessing the campaign's ability to drive new sign-ups and long-term platform use. Additionally, surveys will be conducted to collect feedback on content relevance and effectiveness, ensuring the campaign resonates with the target audience. The ultimate goal is to position Adobe Express as a valuable tool in students' creative and professional development.

Appendix

Survey Visualizations

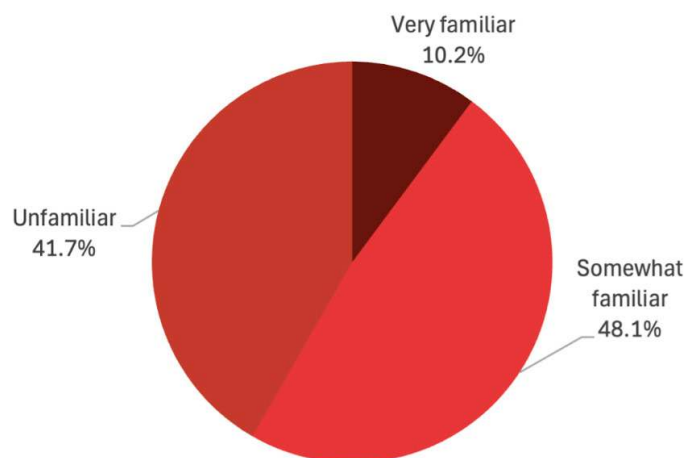
Graph 1: College Students' Willingness to Pay for Monthly Graphic Design Platforms

How much would you be willing to pay for a graphic design platform monthly?



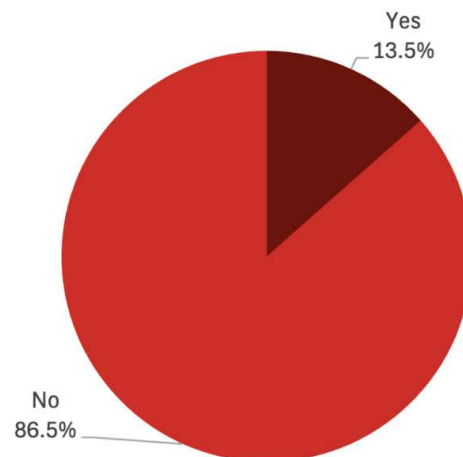
Graph 2: College Students' Familiarity Levels with Adobe Programs

Familiarity level with any Adobe programs

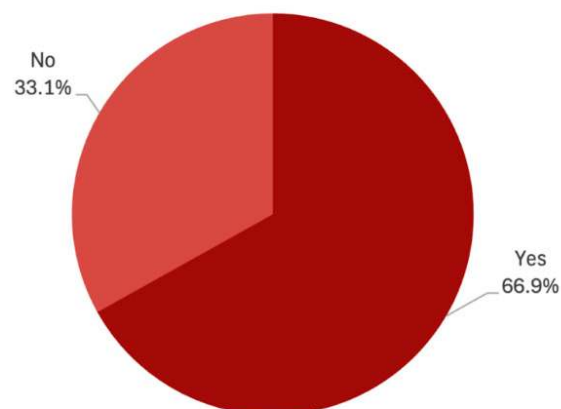


Graph 3: College Students' Experience Using Adobe Express

Have you ever used Adobe Express personally?

**Graph 4: College Students' Willingness to Switch to Adobe Express**

Would you ever consider switching from your current content creation platform to Adobe Express



Survey Question Samples

What do you NOT like about your current content creation platform? *

- ☐ Not enough features
- ☐ It's difficult to use
- ☐ The premium version of the platform is above my price range
- ☐ There is no free version or the free version is too limited in features
- ☐ I can't collaborate with other people on the same project at the same time
- ☐ Nothing, I'm happy with the platform I use
- ☐ Other: _____

What do you care about most when choosing a content creation platform? *

- ☐ Affordability
- ☐ How easy it is to use/learn the platform
- ☐ The range of features the platform offers
- ☐ Whether I can easily and seamlessly collaborate with others on the same project
- ☐ Other: _____

Campaign Social Asset Mock-Ups

Images 1-3: "Rep Your Colors" Social Asset Mock-Ups

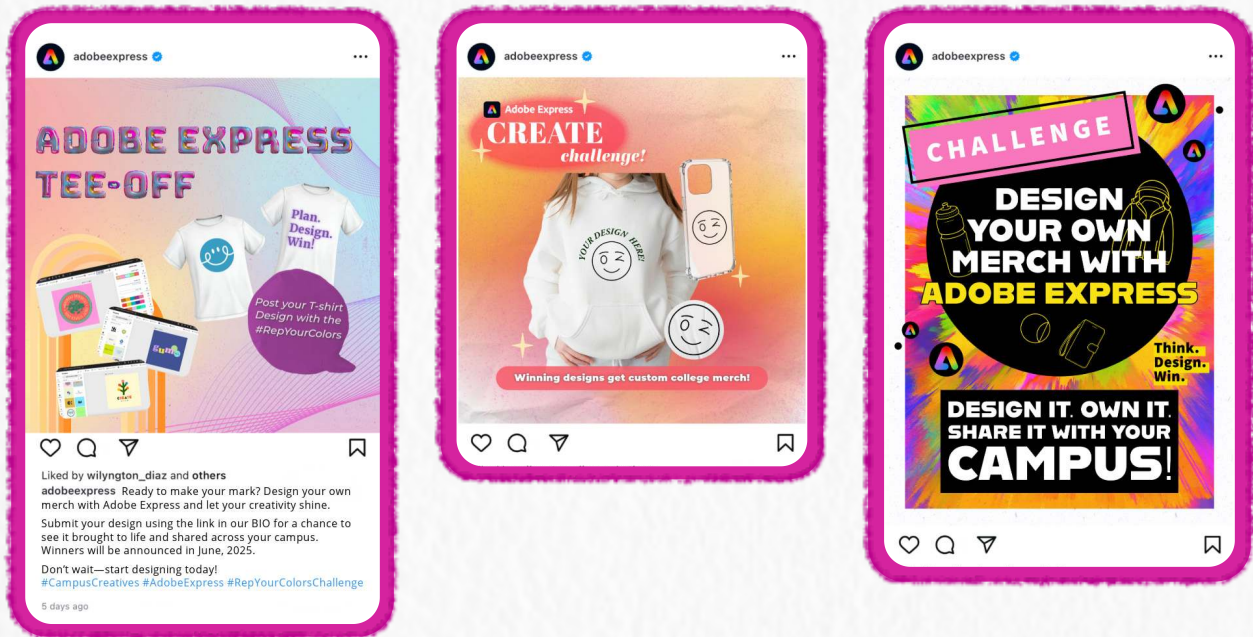


Image 4: #ExpressYourself & Social Influencer Social Asset Mock-Up

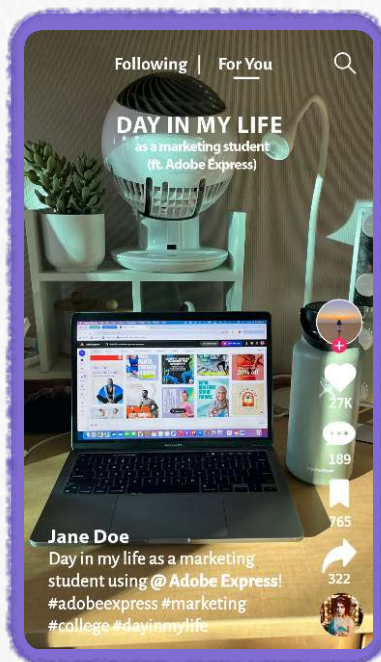
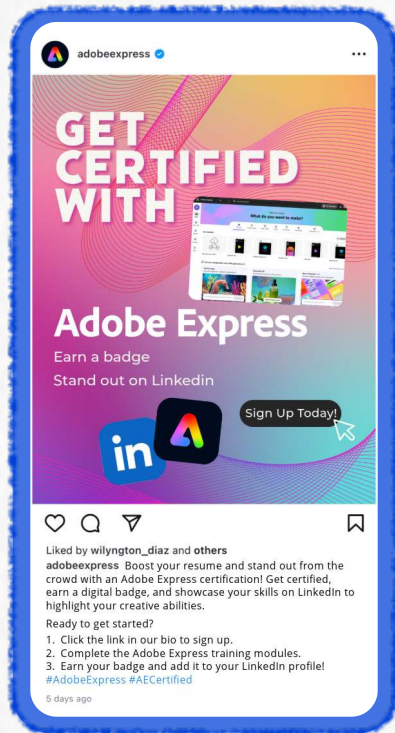
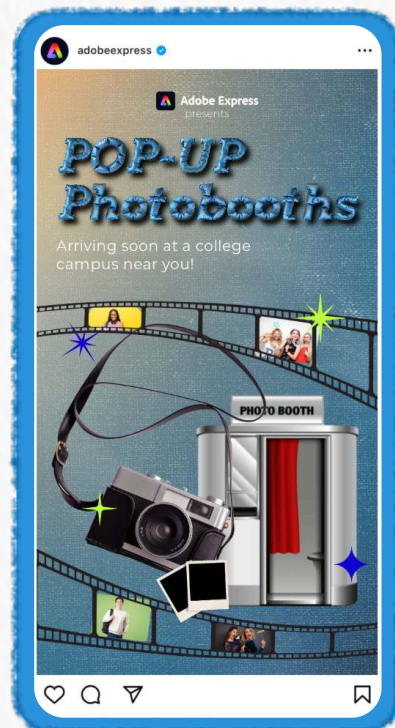


Image 5: "Success with Express" Social Asset Mock-Up



Images 6-7: Photobooth Event Pop-Up Social Asset Mock-Ups



Campaign Budgets

Merchandise Design Competition 2025-2026 Budget:

Category:	Cost:
Ambassador Costs	\$1,000,000
Instagram Influencers	\$500,000
TikTokers	\$500,000
Total Cost	\$2,000,000

Item	Per Item Price	Small School	Medium School	Large School
Tote bags	\$5	\$50,000	\$75,000	\$150,000
Hats	\$4	\$40,000	\$60,000	\$120,000
Crewnecks	\$17	\$170,000	\$255,000	\$510,000
Stickers	\$0.20	\$500	\$1,000	\$2,000
Total Cost:	N/A	\$260,500	\$391,000	\$782,000

"Success with Express" 2025-2026 Budget:

Activity:	Cost Per Item:	Total:
Campus Visits	\$5,000 x 150	\$750,000
LinkedIn Workshops	\$2,500 x 150	\$375,000
Professional Development Workshops	\$2,500 x 150	\$375,000
Advertising With Local College Influencers	\$500 x 150	\$75,000
Total Cost:	N/A	\$1,575,000

College-Aged Influencer Marketing 2025-2026 Budget:

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	TOTALS
Instagram	$10k + 7500 + 75 + 500 = \$93,000$	$10k + 75 + 500 = \$10,575$	$10k + 7500 + 500 + 75 = \$18,075$	$10k + 7500 + 500 + 75 = \$18,075$	\$139,725
TikTok	$(25 \times 10) + (125 \times 10) + (1200 \times 10) + (2500 \times 10) + (2500 \times 10) = \$63,500$	$(25 \times 10) + (125 \times 10) + (1200 \times 10) + (2500 \times 10) + (2500 \times 10) = \$63,500$	$(25 \times 10) + (125 \times 10) + (1200 \times 10) + (2500 \times 10) + (2500 \times 10) = \$63,500$	$(25 \times 10) + (125 \times 10) + (1200 \times 10) + (2500 \times 10) + (2500 \times 10) = \$63,500$	\$254,000
YouTube	$(200 \times 5) + (5000 \times 5) + (10000 \times 5) + (20000 \times 5) + (20000 \times 5) = \$251,000$	$(200 \times 5) + (5000 \times 5) + (10000 \times 5) + (20000 \times 5) + (20000 \times 5) = \$251,000$	$(200 \times 5) + (5000 \times 5) + (10000 \times 5) + (20000 \times 5) + (20000 \times 5) = \$251,000$	$(200 \times 5) + (5000 \times 5) + (10000 \times 5) + (20000 \times 5) + (20000 \times 5) = \$251,000$	\$1,004,000
Influencer Content Creation Trips	$10 \text{ college influencers} \times \$25,000 = \$250,000$	$10 \text{ college influencers} \times \$25,000 = \$250,000$	$10 \text{ college influencers} \times \$25,000 = \$250,000$	$10 \text{ college influencers} \times \$25,000 = \$250,000$	\$1,000,000
TOTAL	\$407,500	\$325,075	\$332,575	\$332,575	\$2,397,725

E-Booth 2025-2026 Budget:

Equipments	Costs
Photobooth Machines	$\$30,000 \times 5 = \$150,000$
Photobooth Adobe Branding Customization	$\$10,000 \times 5 = \$50,000$
Camera and Lighting	$\$20,000 \times 5 = \$100,000$
Photo Printers + Film	\$100,000
Software Cost	$\$5,000 \times 5 = \$50,000$
Cost to Transport Machines to Other Campuses + Man Power	\$150,000

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